

Berkeley Neighbors for Housing & Climate Action 2026 Candidate Questionnaire

Candidate Name: Daria Wrubel

District / Office being sought: Berkeley City Council - District 1

1. Berkeley's Housing Element lays out the city's plan for new housing construction through 2031, ensuring the city can meet its Regional Housing Needs Allocation (RHNA) of ~9,000 homes across a range of income levels.

The Housing Element commits Berkeley to a number of major policy changes in order to meet state requirements for affirmatively furthering fair housing, including a San Pablo Specific Plan and upzoning along North Shattuck, Solano, and College Ave, among other items.

What is your view on the Housing Element and these policies? What are the most important things we need to do to implement the City's Housing Element?

Please discuss your ideas and priorities around:

- a. San Pablo specific plan
- b. Zoning for housing in high-resource commercial areas like North Shattuck, Solano, and College Ave
- c. Extending 'middle housing' zoning to some parts of the Hills, while balancing fire risk
- d. Other strategies for Berkeley to affirmatively further fair housing

Berkeley's 2023–2031 Housing Element is a strong framework. It's success depends on implementation rather than promises.

Berkeley's 2025 Housing Element progress report shows the city received complete applications representing 755 proposed units in 2025, substantially fewer than the 3,832 proposed in 2024 — showing why implementation matters.

Berkeley needs to welcome more housing in every part of the city, particularly neighborhoods that historically have been difficult for lower and middle income families.

The challenge is to create enough capacity for projects that pencil out — which includes affordable housing requirements, density and height considerations, regular approvals, and parking mandates — and that actually get built.

San Pablo Avenue in my district has always been a logical place for new housing, being a major transit and commercial corridor. The challenge is to protect the small businesses, renters, and communities vulnerable to displacement. As council member, areas I would like to focus include ground floor retail expectations, building sustainability standards, and small business assistance.

North Shattuck, Solano, and College are high resource corridors, which gives an opportunity for more equitable distribution of housing. Economically feasible taller buildings with thoughtful building-form standards that preserve the neighborhood's character would offer benefits to these areas where affordable housing is scarce. I would seek to incorporate these values in the upcoming zoning ordinance planning.

I am in support of Berkeley's middle-housing zoning — allowing for more duplexes, triplexes, and courtyard apartments — but wish to monitor programs to see if it's actually producing more homes. That means assessing setbacks, subdivision rules, and floor limits as barriers. The fire risk in the Hills is real. This is where ADUs and duplexes with fire resistant building standards and vegetation management makes sense for public safety. Wildfire evacuation risk demands stricter standards in hazardous areas.

My principle is that Berkeley should be a city where more people can afford to live. I am proud to be the pro-affordability, pro-fair-housing, and pro-tenant candidate in this election.

2. Berkeley's Climate Action Plan sets forth a goal of 80% reduction in greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions by 2050. Today, the two major sources of GHG emissions in Berkeley are from gas-powered automobiles and natural gas used in buildings.

Berkeley has a variety of plans and programs intended to help address these emissions, including the Electric Mobility Roadmap and the Berkeley Existing Building Electrification Strategy. Other related efforts include the Bicycle Plan and Pedestrian Master Plan, as well as the City's now-defunct natural gas ban on new buildings.

What is your view on the Climate Action Plan and these strategies? What are the most important things we need to do to address greenhouse gas emissions?

I am a strong supporter of Berkeley's Climate Action Plan.

Berkeley cannot solve the challenges of climate change by continuing to be an expensive low growth city. To tackle the city's Greenhouse emissions by transportation (58%) and buildings (39%) we need to be a city where working families live close to jobs, where biking and transit are a safe convenience, and where we create model sustainable buildings. Housing is a climate policy - building sustainably around transit and commerce corridors, infill housing, and expanding building electrification reduce greenhouse gases.

As council member, a concern is electrification becoming an affordability problem. Renters and low income homeowners shouldn't have to take on full electrical upgrading, replacing furnaces, and accompanying fixtures without assistance -- which can run up to tens of thousands of dollars. The city should help supplement these costs.

To sustain our environmental mission, we must show how stronger climate policies produce benefits for our residents. Lower utility bills, cleaner air, quieter streets, better sidewalks, more trees, and affordable housing.

3. In your opinion, what was the most important City Council vote on Berkeley's housing crisis in the past four years? Briefly describe the issue, what you think of the Council's decision, and what you would have done had you been on the Council. For incumbents, please describe why you voted the way you did, and what you think now about that vote.

By my estimation, the Council's most important housing vote in the last four years is the 2025 Middle Housing ordinance.

For decades, Berkeley's residential land restricted multifamily housing. The Council changed those rules to allow duplexes, triplexes, and other multifamily buildings in low-density neighborhoods.

If I was council member at that time, I would have supported this measure because solving Berkeley's housing shortage requires creating housing opportunities throughout the city, not just Downtown. While protecting existing tenants and preserving affordable housing, along with wildfire evacuation analysis, I would have pushed for uniform rules for housing to get built.

My larger principle is that we can't say housing is a crisis while making new housing difficult to build. Middle housing is one important way to create more homes, broaden access to high-resource neighborhoods and make Berkeley more economically inclusive.

4. In your opinion, what was the most important climate or environmental issue faced by the Berkeley City Council in the last four years? Briefly describe the issue, what you think of the Council's decision, and what you would have done had you been on the Council. For incumbents, please describe why you voted the way you did, and what you think now about that vote.

In 2019, Berkeley became the first U.S. city to prohibit natural-gas infrastructure in new buildings in 2019.

The policy would have prevented new buildings from becoming locked into fossil-fuel usage and reduce greenhouse-gas emissions and indoor combustion pollution.

In April 2023, the Ninth Circuit killed the natural-gas ban.

Losing one legal battle should not mean abandoning Berkeley's pioneering building electrification goals.

If I was council member, I would have accelerated heat-pump and heat-pump-water-heater adoption, strengthened building-performance policies, expanded incentives and direct-install programs for low-income households, required all-electric construction in City projects, and worked with the state and neighboring jurisdictions on electrification standards.

Most importantly, I would work to make the transition equitable. Low-income homeowners and renters shouldn't bear the cost of solving the climate crisis. Berkeley should use subsidies, financing and direct installation so the households least able to afford electrification receive the greatest assistance. There is going to be an increasing demand for electrification. I will be the champion to make Berkeley a model and a leader in doing it right.

5. To achieve its RHNA goals, Berkeley must continue to build homes for all income levels. These new residents will need to travel within Berkeley. Greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions from transportation comprise roughly 60% of total emissions in Berkeley.

How would you ensure that Berkeley continues to reduce GHG emissions while adding new homes?

I've explored aspects of this question in previous answers. I will try and sum up my principles that I want to put housing where people don't have to drive, make transit reliable and faster, build a protected bike lane network, make walking safer, electrify buildings, and make middle housing part of our climate vision policies.

I would like to emphasize vehicle miles traveled per capita, rather than just the number of cars. If we could decrease the need for vehicles as population expands, the per-capita transportation emissions could fall substantially. It should be noted the success of bike and scooter rental services in Berkeley --estimated close to a million miles worth of trips made in our city last year, 35% of the trips linking to public transit -- is now an integral part of our public transit network.

Berkeley should also prioritize micro-mobility parking/storage in new developments, while making sure the cost of public transit passes are cheaper for residents than the cost of parking permits. As council member, these will be the goals I will always be forwarding.

6. Walking and biking presents opportunities to help Berkeley residents reduce their GHG emissions, but safety concerns can be a major deterrent.

What is your perspective on how we should address pedestrian and cyclist safety on our streets?

Pedestrian and bicycle safety is also a climate policy.

I am an enthusiastic supporter of the City's 2026 Bicycle Plan. My vision for Berkeley is a city with a connected protected bicycle network - where we focus not just on "low stress" corridors, but aim for "high comfort". This includes the need to build safe connections through major intersections and commercial corridors.

There is a pressing need to fix our most dangerous intersections (around San Pablo and Addison, Adeline and Ashby, MLK to Dwight, College and Ashby etc.), slowing cars down, enforcement for daylight intersections, maintaining ADA compliant sidewalks, and prioritizing safe routes to schools. I constantly hear from District 1 residents about the speeding automobiles around schools and vehicles out of pedestrian sight lines.

I would use collision and safety data to direct investments to prevent injuries, and I would make sure our infrastructure works for cyclists, children, seniors and people with disabilities. Where safety improvements require removing parking or repurposing vehicle lanes, I am prepared to make those choices when the evidence supports them. If Berkeley fails in safety for our pedestrians and cyclists, we will fail as a climate resilient city.

7. Berkeley has a long history of using zoning, restrictive covenants and redlining to achieve racial and economic segregation. This history continues to shape Berkeley today.

Recent research by the Turner Center at UC Berkeley suggests that inclusionary zoning requirements, which mandate on-site restricted affordable housing in new developments, may have the effect of reducing overall housing construction, including the production of affordable units. However, on-site affordable housing can also be an effective tool for desegregating neighborhoods.

What is your perspective on how Berkeley should use inclusionary zoning requirements, versus other affordable housing development options (such as in-lieu fees)?

Berkeley shouldn't have to choose between inclusionary housing and housing productions. We need both. The challenge is in not setting requirements impossibly high that fewer affordable housing units get built. Eliminating inclusionary requirements would abandon an important source of affordable housing and economic integration. We need to pair inclusionary requirement with larger development capacity, and revisit requirements as the economics change.

I support how Berkeley deposits in-lieu fees into its Housing Trust Fund, which should be strategically utilized for land acquisition and preservation of existing affordable building, including acquisition of sites in high-resource neighborhoods. We need to explore bold new revenue measures, like a commercial vacancy tax, to further raise money for the Housing Trust Fund.

The goal should be to find the highest sustainable requirement that still allows substantial housing production. I am open to learning about other strategies, but you have my dedication to using housing policy to undo Berkeley's history of exclusion and injustice.